

Khmer Rouge Victory in Cambodia

General Lon Nol proved an unstable ruler for Cambodia. Following sustained attacks against Nol's regime and the withdrawal of US aid, the Khmer Rouge achieved their goal of ultimate control. The extermination of all threats to the new order soon followed.

◀◀ BEFORE

With Cambodia dragged into the war, the Khmer Rouge steadily grew while the Cambodian government unraveled.

DOMESTIC UNREST

The **Khmer Rouge** spent years gaining strength in the countryside. In 1970, a **coup** left general Lon Nol in charge of Cambodia. Phnom Penh had been the Cambodian capital since the fall of the Angkor kingdom. Although the city benefited from **American aid** during Lon Nol's government, Nixon's **secret bombing** of the Cambodia/Vietnam border placed great strain on the city. Many **refugees** flocked to Phnom Penh or into the ranks of the Khmer Rouge.

After the Paris Accords in 1973, the Khmer Rouge separated themselves from the NVA and conducted an independent insurgency against Lon Nol's Cambodian Republic. US bombing shifted from North Vietnam and Laos to concentrate on the rebels in Cambodia. The Khmer Rouge intensely increased their efforts to secure the country. Their ultimate target was the capital of Phnom Penh. During 1973 and 1974, the Khmer Rouge encircled the capital and engaged the Cambodian Republic Army. US bombing protected Phnom Penh from the Khmer Rouge in 1974, but Lon Nol's army was systematically weakened.

Mysticism and corruption

In his years in power, Lon Nol had become increasingly authoritarian. His deteriorating health led him to depend on soothsayers and Buddhist mystics—during one Khmer Rouge assault on Phnom Penh, he sprinkled a line of holy sand around the city in order to defend it. Overrun by desperate refugees from the countryside who lived in squalor and were exploited by the government, Phnom Penh depended on US aid to survive. Lon Nol's regime was despised by both the city's refugees and native inhabitants.

Khmer Rouge attack

By 1975, the Khmer Rouge had conquered almost all of Cambodia, with the exception of Phnom Penh and the Preah Vihear Temple at the northern border with Thailand. They controlled the roads into the city and placed mines in the Mekong River to stop river traffic.

Their artillery and rocket bombardment of Phnom Penh got underway in January 1974. More than 100,000 homes were destroyed and thousands of people were killed. By March 1975, the city's airfield was destroyed and the US could no longer airlift ammunition and rice into Phnom Penh. Under pressure from the antiwar movement at home, and the failure of the campaign to deter the Khmer Rouge, the US terminated further assistance to the Cambodian government. The fate of the Lon Nol regime was sealed. On April 1, Cambodian government and military leaders forced Lon Nol to resign and leave the country.

They hoped, fruitlessly, that the gesture would lead the Khmer Rouge to open negotiations rather than assault the capital. On April 12, the US closed its embassy. After months spent on the outskirts of the city, the Khmer Rouge forces entered Phnom Penh on